Nazi party were declared illegal. The army of brown-shirted and jack-booted storm-troopers was expanded. The Hitler Youth was created, and the Labour Front set up. Trade unions were abolished, their leaders were arrested and all workers were compelled to join the German Labour Front. Strikes were made illegal, wages were fixed by the government, and the Labour Front was used by the Nazis to control industry. Total state control was extended over the press, the theatre, the cinema, radio and over education.

The Nazi Party's propaganda was led by Joseph Goebbels, who manipulated public opinion through planned propaganda. He once said, 'any lie frequently repeated will ultimately gain belief.' The Gestapo or Secret State Police was formed and run by Himmler, who controlled the select bodyguard of Hitler.

Nazi Policy towards Jews

Along with the repressive measures, Hitler's government followed a policy of repressing Jewish people. The Jews were removed from government positions, excluded from the universities and deprived of citizenship. Jewish businesses were closed down, and their establishments were attacked. After the outbreak of World War II concentration camps, barracks surrounded by electrified fences and watch towers, were built where Jews were interred and used as forced labour with less than subsistence nourishment. Later they were turned into extermination camps where industrial means of murder such as gas chambers were used to kill Jews. It is estimated that about 6 million Jews in Europe were killed in what the Nazis termed 'The Final Solution'. Apart from Jews, the Nazi state also exterminated gypsies, and other itinerant communities, homosexuals and lunatics. Apart from these, several hundreds of thousands of Germans who dissented with Hitler too were killed.

Defiance of the Treaty of Versailles

In August 1934 Hindenburg died and Hitler, apart from being Chancellor, became both President and Commander-in-Chief of the armed forces. By 1938 the Nazi Party had tightened its control over the army. Hitler's foreign policy aimed at restoring the armed strength of Germany and annulling provisions of Versailles Treaty which undermined Germany. His deliberate attempts to breach the Treaty of Versailles (discussed in the next lesson) led to the outbreak of Second World War.

Summary

- Transition from Mercantilism to Industrial capitalism and then to financial capitalism culminating in Imperialism is explained.
- Markets for selling surplus manufactured goods and for obtaining raw materials leading to search for colonies and the resultant conflict amongst great powers in Europe are discussed.
- Rise of Japan as an imperial power in Asia and its expansionist policy are highlighted.
- Europe organising into two warring camps resulting in the formation of alliances and counter-alliances are detailed.
- Important factors responsible for the outbreak of World War I, aggressive attitude of Germany, France's hostility towards Germany for the loss of its territories, Alsace and Lorraine, Japan's expansionist policy, power politics in Balkans are explained.
- Conduct of War in frontiers and important battles in other theatres of war are described.
- Causes, course and results of Russian Revolution are analysed.
- America's entry into the War in the context of launching of submarines by Germany and the decisive outcome of the War in favour of the Allies are outlined.
- Paris Peace Conference and the results of the War are elaborated.
- The League of Nations and its role in promoting peace are critically examined.
- Rise of Fascist governments and their fallout are described.

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